My Tiny Dancer's Hands
By Cynthia Riebesell

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The Intriguing Interp Series
is published by
Mushroom Cloud Press
Orlando, FL

For more information and performance rights, contact
Mushroom Cloud Press
278 Leslie Lane
Lake Mary, FL 32746
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http://www.mushroomcloudpress.com/

ISSN listed in graphic seal below.



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The play you are about to read is about a young lesbian woman named Ingrid. Her partner, Molly, goes into a coma after being beaten up by a few homophobic bullies. Ingrid sits by Molly's bedside and tells their story. According to the South Carolina PFLAG website, 45% of gay men and 20% of lesbians experience physical or verbal assault in high school. However, the percentage is just a number, and the pain that these numbers are trying to describe is often hidden. For Ingrid, the only way to understand others' cruelty is through a journey for peace in My Tiny Dancer's Hands.

My Tiny Dancer's Hands

By Cynthia Riebesell

Father? Son? Holy Ghost?

I'm not used to this, this whole praying thing. I'm just looking for someone to talk to. **(Pause)** I've been sitting here next to Molly's bedside since the day she was brought into the hospital. To think that all of this started because we were holding hands. Oh MOLLY, I can still feel the lightness that your hands brought. But because WE were holding hands, it's considered an abomination.

I can remember the exact day I fell in love with Molly. We had been at a bonfire. We were sitting next to each other up until the point she heard Elton John's 'Tiny Dancer' come on the radio, and she leapt to her feet, in excitement. **(pause)** I remember she pulled back the brown curls from her face, and slowly began moving to the music's melody. **(pause)** She lifted her hands up towards the sky and then closed her eyes, as if taking in the night's perfection. Oh, MOLLY you were so beautiful. But then to feel her hand placed in mine, to know that she was mine only made it all the more mesmerizing.

She is so simple, so laid back, and so completely self-less. She cares for people who may not even deserve her sympathy. The kind of people who mock her, she gives <u>sympathy</u> to. The kind of people who say things behind her back, she gives <u>sympathy</u> to. The kind of people who want to cause her pain, SHE gives <u>sympathy</u> to. Now, she's lying here, lapsed in a coma because that sympathy went unnoticed. Who Molly is as a person

didn't matter to them. The only thing they cared about was whose hand she was holding and they**(pause)** didn't **(pause)** like **(pause)** it.

I was reading the newspaper one morning and I read an article about a man named Preston being interviewed about his elementary school experience in Decatur, Alabama. In his P.E. class, his fellow peers rather enjoyed a game, similar to dodge ball called "smear the queer". Preston asked his teacher if they could maybe play a different game. Instead Preston's teacher said "No, but you can be the queer for the day." And for the rest of the class, Preston's classmates ran, throwing dodge balls at him because he was the designated queer.

Some people may say that being homosexual is immoral or unnatural, but how is treating people in such an obscene way *natural.* And how is beating someone up bad enough to knock them into a coma *natural*?

Whenever I see Molly in this hospital bed, bruises all over her face, arms, and legs, I feel hopeless. In school, we've dealt with people making comments, calling us dykes, Lesbos, and queers. But we never let it get to us, did we MOLLY? After all they were just words. You would just take my hand and smile at me. **(look up to GOD)**Nothing was better than when she took my hand. It was her way of assuring me that everything would be alright. One time, after Sadie McDowell told me my 'reasoning' for being a lesbian was because I'm an ugly, butch girl who can't find herself a boyfriend, Molly just took my hand, and said "There's nothing we can't get through as long as your hand is in mine."

You know, it would have been the perfect surprise. It was Valentine's Day, the night she ended up here. Molly and I weren't able to spend Valentine's Day together because I had to go to work as soon as school was over. I promised her I'd take her to the fanciest restaurant in town the next day for a belated Valentine's date. That night, I got home around 10 P.M. and I was getting ready for bed when I heard a knock at the door. I opened it but no one was there. But then I looked down, and there was a teddy bear with

the words I Love You inscribed on its tummy. Next to the bear, there was a folded up note. It said: "I couldn't wait for tomorrow. I wanted you to know how happy I am to have you as my Valentine. I love you, Ingrid."

But that's when I heard the scream coming from down the street. They had been waiting for her by her car.

And because she was alone, because it was dark and she was out of sight, because she's a lesbian and because Sadie and her gang of homophobic friends decided to play their own game of 'smear the queer' and because her hand wasn't in mine is why the world's friendliest girl and the love of my life is lying here in a coma.

I just wish that there was peace like the vision in my mind. Peace like the smell of grass. Peace like the taste of sunbeams. Peace like the feeling of doves and olive branches. And I see Molly. Molly, in a white chiffon sundress that falls from her shoulders. I wish this vision would stay.

And I can see her dancing.

Dancing as if her pain is completely invisible.

And she smiles- and those passionate hazel eyes lock to mine and I know she is at peace.

And she puts out her hand motioning me to come join her.

"Hold me closer." My tiny dancer says and I'm tempted. Tempted to take her hand and get lost within this beautiful love song. But this Molly…this Molly doesn't need me.

This Molly needs me and as much as I long to feel that peace. As much as I long to just escape it all, it's the real Molly who needs that peace. And if there's one thing I can do, it's to stay here by her side, hold her hand and hope **(deep breath)** hope she wakes up.

Molly? Molly, can you hear me? Because if you can, there is nothing we can't get through as long as your hand is in mine.